Failure-by-Language: Reproducible Evaluation of Python-like Confusion Language in LLM Code Generation

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***Abstract*—Recent studies on AI-assisted coding suggest a persistent gap between short-term productivity gains and durable programming comprehension. This paper proposes a reproducible benchmark for syntax-constrained code generation: language models are instructed to write Python-like programs under transformed-token rules. We present an OCaml/CLI pipeline with lineage-aware task metadata, schema validation, and metric snapshot automation. Current empirical results are limited by temporary LLM API authentication failures; however, fixture replay experiments still provide a controlled baseline for measuring alias compliance, Python reversion, and execution success behavior.**

***Index Terms*—confusion language, LLM code generation, syntax perturbation, benchmark, reproducibility, program synthesis**

I. Introduction

Recent studies on AI-assisted coding indicate a persistent tradeoff: immediate coding productivity may rise while durable comprehension and independent debugging skills lag, especially for beginners. This motivates evaluation under constrained syntax settings rather than only canonical benchmarks.

This study asks a strict question: when a model is instructed to produce code in a Python-like language with transformed syntax, does it follow the transformed language rules, or revert to canonical Python conventions?

We define a three-layer benchmark stack:

1) **Specification layer**: one-to-one token aliases and collision constraints.
2) **Execution layer**: OCaml-based transform, validate, and roundtrip tooling.
3) **Measurement layer**: summary validation, schema checks, and metric snapshots.

Our goal is not absolute model ranking. We isolate where constrained-language compliance fails and how failures relate to execution outcomes.

II. Related Work

A. Code-generation benchmarks and robustness

Code-generation benchmarks and model baselines (e.g., HumanEval and MBPP) motivate short-horizon program synthesis evaluation. [1], [2]

B. Code representation models under perturbation

Pretraining work such as *CodeBERT*, *CodeT5*, and *UniXcoder* improves code representation transfer, while preserving language semantics under transformed-token constraints remains underexplored in these settings. [3], [4], [5]

C. Instruction and alignment effects

Instruction-following tuning improves broad task compliance, yet its effect on non-standard syntax transformations has not been studied sufficiently. [6], [7]

D. Repair-oriented generation

Editing and infilling methods (e.g., InCoder) indicate that bidirectional context can support local correction, relevant to our roundtrip diagnosis design. [8]

E. Software-engineering realism

SWE-bench demonstrates the gap between benchmark-scale success and real-world patching complexity, reinforcing our emphasis on strict artifact and lineage control. [9]

F. Constraint-aware decoding

Recent progress in constrained decoding suggests adding semantic constraints can complement syntax-layer methods, an important extension direction for confusion-language pipelines. [10]

III. Method

A. Language Setup

We define a Python-like confusion language by replacing selected Python tokens with aliases. The transformation enforces:

1) one-to-one mapping between each source token and its alias;
2) no alias sharing among control keywords (e.g., `if` and `elif`);
3) token-boundary replacement while preserving comments and string/regex literals.

B. System Pipeline

The implementation combines OCaml transformations with Python evaluators:

- alias/lineage validation and roundtrip conversion in `ocaml-confusion-lang`;
- generation summary and mapping scripts in `ocaml-confusion-lang/scripts`;
- metric aggregation and schema validation via `batch_report_summary.py`, `generate_metric_snapshot.py`, `validate_summary_payload.py`, and `validate_metric_schema.py`.

C. Metrics

We define:

- ACR (Alias Compliance Rate)
- PRR (Python Reversion Rate)
- ESR (Execution Success Rate)
- MFB (Manual Fix Burden)
- LGP (Learning Gain Proxy)

D. Experiment Configuration

Primary runs are controlled by fixture task/task-alias pairs (e.g., `fixture-task-set-v1`, `fixture-alias-v1`) and prompt conditions (`strict` baseline). Live API calls are executed through the batch path when credentials are available; otherwise, fixture replay is used for reproducibility checks.

IV. Experiments

A. Run protocol

Each run follows these steps:

1) Prepare task-set metadata and prompt condition.
2) Execute model batch or fixture replay.
3) Validate summary payloads and metric snapshots, then archive in `docs/research/results/`.

B. Execution coverage

Current coverage includes:

- fixture summary replay with full artifact generation (JSON/CSV/Markdown) and schema validation;
- planner/state-code regression expansion;
- robust parsing output via compact JSON/JSONL/TSV/markdown formats.

C. Failure conditions observed

Live LLM batch calls are blocked by authentication failures (HTTP 401) in the current environment. Earlier local execution failures were additionally caused by missing environment dependencies (e.g., `dune`) and were resolved before this phase.

D. Reproducibility protocol

Every run is committed with provenance fields and lineage IDs (task-set, alias-set, prompt config, and run metadata) so that mismatches are auditable and not silently conflated with tool drift.

TABLE I
Initial aggregate metrics from replayed fixture run.

Metric	Value	Note
ACR	0.333	fixture replay (`fixture-task-set-v1`)
PRR	0.667	same run condition
ESR	0.667	same run condition
MFB	65.0	manual correction burden estimate
LGP	0.667	learning proxy metric from replay context

V. Results

A. Live API attempts

A 12-prompt real-call batch against `gpt-4o-mini` is currently blocked:

- **passed=0**, **failed=12**
- primary failure: HTTP 401 unauthorized.

B. Failure taxonomy (replay)

Observed dominant mismatch classes are:

- `line_count_mismatch`
- `whitespace_or_blankline_drift`
- `token_stream_mismatch`
- `token_substitution_mismatch`

These patterns indicate both surface-form instability and transformation-format fragility.

VI. Discussion

The current stage contributes a robust benchmark scaffold rather than definitive model-ranking results.

A. Validated contributions

We confirmed replay-side reproducibility: fixture summaries and metric snapshots are generated, versioned, and schema-checked. CLI expansion for planner/state outputs reduced parser ambiguity and enabled compact machine-parsable artifacts.

B. Remaining limits

- Live model comparisons are blocked by API authentication issues (401), so cross-model conclusions are preliminary.
- Real-world task breadth is still limited due to restricted batch expansion.

C. Methodological implication

For constrained-language evaluation, provenance and schema control are first-order requirements. Without them, failure diagnosis is easily confounded by tooling drift or lineage mismatch, not model behavior.

VII. Conclusion

This project delivers a reproducible confusion-language benchmark stack with collision-safe alias policies, provenance-rich output, and schema-enforced measurements.

Current quantitative evidence is limited: fixture replay indicates non-trivial non-compliance and Python reversion under transformed syntax, while real API-based model expansion awaits valid credentials.

Next steps are to (1) complete cross-condition batch comparisons, (2) report mismatch decomposition over larger prompt sets, and (3) integrate learner-centered diagnostics (manual-fix burden and learning-gain trajectory) into the same pipeline.

VIII. Reproducibility and Artifact Availability

All scripts, logs, and metrics are versioned in the repository. Representative paths:

- Tooling: `ocaml-confusion-lang/`
- Results: `docs/research/results/`
- Logs: `docs/research/log/`
- Status snapshot: `docs/research/context-state.json`
- Paper draft: `docs/research/papers/v2.md`

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